

1845. It is an irony of fate that the indigenous schools of India should thus contribute to the spread of education in England and be of no avail in spreading mass education in India herself!

CHAPTER TWO

The East India Company Accepts Responsibility for the Education of Indians

(1600-1813)

Proselytizing and Educational Activities of the East India Company (1600-1765): The East India Company was, in this period, a primarily commercial concern and it is, therefore, not proper to expect it to take any steps for the education of the Indian people. But N. N. Law points out that, even in these early years, the Company was engaged in fostering some proselytizing and educational activities within its possessions. As early as in 1614, steps were taken "for the recruitment of Indians for the propagation of the Gospel among their countrymen and for imparting to these missionaries such education, at the Company's expense, as would enable them to carry out effectively the purposes for which they were enlisted".¹ It is also on record that an Indian youth, christened *Peter* by King James I, was taken to England for education in the Christian doctrine although what he did later on is not known.² In 1659, the Court of Directors explicitly stated that it was their earnest desire by all possible means to spread Christianity among the people of India and allowed missionaries to embark on their ships.³ This evangelical zeal found support in contemporary England where the Church was experiencing the revival of a deep religious fervour so that, when the Charter of the Company was renewed in 1698, the famous *missionary clause* was inserted in it by Parliament. This clause directed the Company to maintain ministers of religion at their factories in India and to take a

¹N. N. Law: *Promotion of Learning in India by Early European Settlers*, pp. 7-8.

²*Ibid.*, p. 7.

³W. H. Sharp: *Selections from Educational Records*, Vol I, p. 3.

Chaplain in every ship of 500 tons or more. The ministers were required to learn the Portuguese language which was then commonly understood by the inferior servants at the factories, and also "to apply themselves to learn the native language of the country where they shall reside, the better to enable them to instruct the Gentoos that shall be the servants or slaves of the same Company or of their agents, in the Protestant religion".¹ The Charter also directed the Company to maintain schools, wherever necessary, in all their garrisons and bigger factories. The first part of this direction obviously implies that the Company was expected to spread the Gospel amongst all the Hindu employees of the Company at least, if not among the people as a whole.

Can these proselytizing activities be regarded as the beginning of the Company's educational enterprise in India?—is the question often raised. Some historians seem to think that they can be; but it is wrong to equate the education of Indians with their conversion to Christianity. Such a view was common among the missionaries and the officers of the East India Company at this period. But no educationist can ever subscribe to it and it would be far more correct to hold that these early proselytizing activities of the Company had nothing to do with the education of the Indian people because they did not, in any way, contribute to the modern movement in education that began in India with the Charter Act of 1813.

What then is the importance of the *missionary clause* contained in the Charter Act of 1698? It may be said to have laid the foundation, not of the education of the Indian people, but of the education of the European and Anglo-Indian children who lived in the possessions of the Company. In accordance with the directions of this Charter, Chaplains were appointed in all the three Presidency towns. They regarded it as their pious duty to look after the education of the Christian children and, in particular, after the welfare and education of the Anglo-Indian children born of the Company's soldiers and their Indian wives. These children were generally neglected and the Chaplains were anxious to claim them for the Christian fold and to educate them properly. With this object in view, they collected subscriptions

¹Sir C. Ilbert: *Government of India*, p. 29.

and established *charity schools*. The name was borrowed from England and indicated that the schools were supported by charity and were primarily meant for poor children or orphans.

Thus arose the most important of the charity schools conducted in India during the eighteenth century. Some idea of their working can be had from the detailed account given by N. N. Law in his interesting book *Promotion of Learning in India by Early European Settlers*. In the years immediately following 1698, the Chaplains of the Company seem to have followed the provisions of the Charter literally and conducted schools in Portuguese which was then the *lingua franca* at the factories of the Company. But the attempt never became popular; it was soon given up and English was adopted as the medium of instruction. The oldest charity school to be established on this new model was *St. Mary's Charity School at Madras founded by Rev. W. Stevenson in 1715*. It was financed by legacies, donations and occasional grants from the Company. In 1719, a charity school was established at Bombay by Rev. Richard Cobbe on the same principles. Chaplain Bellamy of Calcutta founded a similar charity school sometime between 1720 and 1731 and it is on record that a new building was constructed for it in 1739. In 1787, a *Female Orphan Asylum* was opened at Madras and named after Lady Campbell, the wife of the Governor, who took a leading part in collecting funds. In the same year, a *Male Asylum* was also started at Madras by Rev. Dr. Andrew Bell, the Chaplain. This school is of great historical importance because it was here that Dr. Bell tried the *monitorial system* which he later introduced in England.

The East India Company assisted these charity schools in various ways. For instance, it (a) sanctioned recurring grants for maintenance; (b) permitted lotteries in their support; (c) gave non-recurring grants for buildings or provided sites; (d) allowed their officers to collect funds or act as school accountants or other office-bearers; (e) occasionally repaired the school buildings; and (f) accepted the funds of the schools as deposits at comparatively higher rates of interest. But when all is said, it must be admitted that these schools were maintained by subscriptions and donations rather than by the grants sanctioned by the Company.

Educational Policy of the Company between 1765 and 1813: After 1765 when the Company became a political power in India, its educational policy underwent a change. **Hitherto, the Company had restricted its attention to the education of European and Anglo-Indian children.** It now began to feel that it must do something for the Indian people. Politically, **it was a successor to Hindu and Muslim rulers who encouraged higher learning in classical languages by (a) establishing *madrassahs* and *pathshalas*, (b) by giving marks of honour or pecuniary grants to learned *Pandits* and *Moulavis*, or (c) by endowing educational institutions for higher religious studies.** It was felt that the Company must continue these traditions. Moreover, the Company wanted to educate sons of influential Indians for higher posts under Government and thereby win the confidence of the upper classes and consolidate its rule in India. It was, therefore, felt that the Company should establish some centres of higher learning for the Hindus and the Muslims—a desire that led to the establishment of institutions entirely different from the charity schools. Among these, the most important were the **Calcutta Madrassah** and the **Banaras Sanskrit College.**

The **Calcutta Madrassah** was founded by **Warren Hastings** in order "to conciliate the Mahomedans of Calcutta. . . to qualify the sons of Mahomedan gentlemen for responsible and lucrative offices in the State, and to produce competent officers for Courts of Justice to which students of the Madrassah on the production of certificates of qualification were to be drafted as vacancies occurred".¹ In the early years, lands yielding Rs. 29,000 (known as Madrassah Mahal) were assigned for the support of the Madrassah. In 1785, the lands were assigned by *Sanad* to Muhammad Muiz-ud-din, the Head of the Madrassah and his successors. But constant complaints regarding inefficiency and mismanagement led finally to the appointment of a European secretary to control the institution and to a guaranteed expenditure of Rs. 30,000 from the State treasury in lieu of assignment in lands.

The **Banaras Sanskrit College** owed its establishment to the same political considerations as had operated in the case of the **Calcutta Madrassah** and was an attempt to conciliate the Hindu population

¹A. Howell: *Education in India*, p. 1.

of the newly acquired territories of the Company. It was founded in 1791 by Jonathan Duncan, the Resident at Banaras, who thus explained the considerations that made him undertake the project:

Two important advantages seemed derivable from such an establishment the first to the British name and nation in its **tendency towards endearing our Government to the native Hindus;** by our exceeding in our attention towards them and their systems, the care shown even by their own native princes. . . . The second principal advantage that may be derived from this institution will be felt in its effect upon the natives. by preserving and disseminating a knowledge of the Hindu law, and proving a nursery of future doctors and expounders thereof, to assist European judges in the due, regular, and uniform administration of its genuine letter and spirit to the body of the people.¹

In the first year of the college, a grant of Rs. 14,000 was sanctioned and it was then raised to Rs. 20,000 per annum. But as in the case of the Madrassah, the affairs of the college continued to be badly managed by the Pandits and, consequently, a European superintendent was appointed to conduct the institution.

Taken together, the Calcutta Madrassah and the Banaras Sanskrit College show the beginning of the **Orientalist School of Educational Policy.** The followers of this school of thought believed that the Company must not lend any support to missionary enterprise and to proselytization; that it need not make any hasty attempt to teach Western knowledge to the Indian people; that its only duty was to **follow in the footsteps of Hindu and Muslim rulers and to encourage classical learning in Sanskrit and Arabic on traditional lines;** and that the ancient system of education which the Hindus and Muslims had inherited was good enough for them for all practical purposes. Obviously, this school of thought was dominated by *political* rather than by educational considerations and decided its policies on grounds of *religious neutrality* or the *political expediency of conciliating the people.* But this was a period when politics, and not education,

¹ W.H. Sharp: *op. cit.*, Vol. I, pp. 11-12.

dominated the Indian scene. The Orientalist views were, therefore, readily accepted by the Court of Directors and between 1765 and 1813, the principal object of the educational policy of the Company was to encourage traditional Oriental learning in Sanskrit and Arabic and the bulk of its educational expenditure was incurred on the maintenance of the Calcutta Madrassah and the Banaras Sanskrit College.

The Reasons Which Led the Missionaries to Undertake Educational Activities: Side by side with these educational activities conducted by the Company, a number of other educational activities were also organised by missionaries who ordinarily worked under the shadow of its political authority. These institutions are of great significance in the history of education in modern India as pioneers of private enterprise in education and deserve detailed notice.

Before, however, coming to their history proper, it is necessary to understand why the missionaries undertook educational activities as an integral part of their work in India. The first and foremost object of the missionaries was to convert people to Christianity and one could not expect them to start educational institutions or to work as teachers. In fact, there was a time in early missionary history when the *Home Authorities* of missions refused to support educational institutions and opined that the priests had no business to found schools. But the practical experience of the early missionaries soon convinced them that they had to start schools as an important means of proselytization. As Rev. Dr. D. O. Allen, an eminent missionary of the American Board, observed:

In commencing their operations, missionaries have generally seen the propriety and importance of establishing schools. One reason for them is to educate the minds of the people, so that they may be more capable of understanding and appreciating the facts and evidences, the doctrines and duties of the Scriptures. Another reason for them is to increase the influence of the missionaries with the people, by communicating some advantage which they can appreciate, and by showing that Christianity rests on an intelligent perception of its doctrines,

and contains reason for the performance of all its duties. And another reason for such an education, is in its procuring means and opening ways of access to the people, and opportunities of preaching to them. One great difficulty which missionaries often experience, is in obtaining access to the people, in circumstances where Christianity can be made the subject of communication or conversation. In such circumstances schools become very important, as a means of communication with different classes of people, with children and parents, and with men and women. And school-houses also become important as places for becoming acquainted with people, for social intercourse and religious worship. School-houses become chapels under the control of missionaries. Their use for this purpose is often more important than for education.¹

In the same way it soon became equally evident that the missions had to conduct schools for the converted population. The early converts to Christianity came mostly from the lowest rung of the Hindu society. They were generally illiterate; and as reading the Bible was held to be essential for salvation, the missionaries were required to establish schools in order to teach the new converts to read and write. For the same reason, they were also compelled to introduce the printing press and to print the Bible in the Indian languages. They had also to start vocational schools and to secure employment under Government to the converts in order to give them a living and a status in society. In fact, the early missionaries found that their work began, rather than ended, with a conversion, and that their main task was not so much the conversion of the people to Christianity as the improvement of the social, cultural and economic condition of the converted people—an object which could only be secured by conducting schools for their education. This duty became all the more urgent because neither the indigenous schools nor the Government schools could admit all the Indian Christian children and they would have remained without any education whatsoever if the missionaries had not organised schools of their own. In short, the missionaries soon realised that schools were both the cause and the effect of proselytization and that educational and mission-

¹R. G. Wilder: *Mission Schools in India*, pp. 36-37.

any work had to be undertaken side by side; and it is out of this realisation that the mission schools of modern India were born.

The Work of the Danish Mission in Madras (1706-92): The honour of being the first Protestant Missionaries to work in the territories of the East India Company goes to the Danish Mission. The famous pioneers of this Mission—Ziegenbalg and Plustschau started their activities at Tranquebar—a Danish station in the South—in 1706. But since the Danes did not obtain a footing in India, most of the Danish missionaries who succeeded these pioneers “substantially identified themselves with the English colonies in South India, halting where they halted and advancing where they advanced”.¹ Other missions that came to India later followed the same policy and, as Richter rightly points out, “modern missionary work in India has as its background and setting the Anglo-Indian Empire; it is intimately connected with the beginnings of that empire; and has extended along with it from one end of the country to the other”.²

Ziegenbalg and his colleagues did considerable missionary and educational work. For example, a printing press in Tamil was established in 1713. An institution for training teachers was opened at Tranquebar in 1716 and, in the following year, two charity schools were opened in Madras—one for Portuguese and the other for Tamil children. Ziegenbalg died in 1719 but his work was continued by other competent missionaries amongst whom may be mentioned the names of Grundler, Kiernander and Schwartz. In Madras, Grundler started, a little before 1717, “a Portuguese school in the White town and a Malabar school in the Black”.³ In 1742, Kiernander founded charity schools for Eurasians as well as Indians in and near Fort St. David. His work became so well known that Clive invited him to Calcutta where in 1758, he founded a charity school. Kiernander continued to work in Bengal for the rest of his life and did the same pioneer service to that Province which Ziegenbalg did to Madras. But even more important was the work of Schwartz who is looked upon as the pioneer of education in the Province of Madras. He founded a

¹J.A. Richter: *A History of Missions in India*, p. 27.

²*Ibid.*, p. 128.

³N.N. Law: *op. cit.*, p. 74.

school for European and Eurasian boys at Trichinopoly (about 1772) and an English Charity School at Tanjore with the help of the purse presented to him by Haider Ali of Mysore. With the assistance of John Sullivan, the Resident at Tanjore, he started three schools at Tanjore, Ramnad and Shivganga in 1785 with the object of teaching English to Indian children. These may be said to be the earliest schools for teaching the English language to Indians and Sullivan hoped that they would help “the Company and the people to understand each other” and to “facilitate dealings of all kinds between them”.¹ “Christianity was not expressly taught (in these schools); nor were any deceitful methods used to instil Christian doctrines into the pupils’ minds.”² The Court of Directors were enthusiastic about them and sanctioned a grant-in-aid of 250 pagodas per annum for each of them.³

It will be seen from the above account that the missionaries were conducting, even at this early date, a number of educational institutions in India; and that these institutions differed from those conducted by the Company’s Chaplains in a number of ways. The mission schools used Indian language as media of instruction; they were meant, not only for European and Anglo-Indian children, but for the converted Indian children in general; and some of them were meant for Indian children and aimed at teaching the English language as a means of communication between the rulers and the ruled. These distinctive features make the educational enterprise of early missionaries even more important than that of Chaplains. Besides, it was the early missionaries who introduced the printing press in India and began the printing of books in Indian languages.

The Company maintained, throughout this period, an attitude of sympathy with this missionary enterprise. In some cases, they gave financial assistance to the mission schools. But what is even more important, they extended benevolent protection and sympathy to all such activities. As Law observes:

In the seventeenth century, we find the Directors taking the initiative in educational work, but the arrival of the missionaries

¹*Ibid.*, p. 65.

²*Ibid.*, p. 68.

³W.H. Sharp : *op. cit.*, Vol. I, pp. 3-4.

in the beginning of the eighteenth century we find a change gradually setting in. They shifted their educational duties to the shoulders of the new-comers, though of course they did not stand aloof altogether. During the first three quarters of the eighteenth century, they gave assistance to schools of various kinds in various ways: they ordered, for instance, their servants at Fort St. David to act in the schools as accountants and occasionally repaired the school buildings. They did not, however, want to have a hand in the actual educational work, so that, up to 1787, all that was done outside Fort St. George, was done by the missionaries either in their capacity as such or as garrison or station chaplains.¹

The Work of the Serampore Trio and Others in Bengal (1758-1813): The Danish missionaries who worked in South in the eighteenth century were indeed lucky because they were able to obtain *benevolent protection* and sympathetic assistance from the East India Company. The missionaries who worked in Bengal, however, were far less fortunate. They had to struggle hard against a hostile attitude and had it not been for the protection given to them by the Dutch Settlements at Serampore and Chinsura, they would hardly have been able to achieve anything at all.

Reference has already been made to the work of **Kiernander**. He was not only the pioneer missionary in Bengal, but had also the good fortune to obtain sympathetic treatment from the Company. He was followed by **Dr. Carey, a representative of the Baptist Missionary Society, in 1793**. He worked for a time at Calcutta; but owing to difficulties, finally shifted to Malda where he superintended an indigo factory and **used all his spare time in translating the New Testament into Bengali**, holding daily religious services for the servants on the estate, preaching among the neighbouring villagers and in supervising a school he had established. In 1799, two other missionaries—**Ward and Marshman**—arrived in Calcutta. Their original object was to join Carey in his work in North Bengal; but they found that the East India Company would not permit them to do so. They, therefore, persuaded Carey to join them and decided to settle

¹N. N. Law: *op. cit.*, p. 33.

down at the Dutch Settlement of Serampore which was only about 15 miles from Calcutta and where the Dutch Governor gave them all the protection they needed. Thus came into existence the famous **Serampore Trio**. Indeed, these three friends formed an excellent combination for mission work because **Carey was a great propagandist, Ward was a printer and Marshman was a school teacher**. They translated and printed the Bible in several languages and also issued a number of tracts on useful subjects. In this connection, Sherring observes:

In no country in the world, and in no period in the history of Christianity, was there ever displayed such an amount of energy in the translation of the Sacred Scriptures from their originals into other tongues, as was exhibited by a handful of earnest men in Calcutta and Serampore in the first ten years of the present century. By their own industry and that of others in various parts of India who had caught from them inspiration for the work, during this short period, **portions of the Bible, chiefly of the New Testament, had been translated, and actually printed, in thirty-one Indian languages and dialects**. One is amazed, and almost overwhelmed, at the stupendousness of this undertaking. It cannot be supposed that these first attempts are to be compared with the versions which have been subsequently made in these languages. But this must not diminish the intense admiration we ought to feel towards men of such boldness of design, and such astounding energy of execution. Not content with their labours in this direction, they also published a great multitude **of tracts, the Serampore press alone issuing them in twenty languages, and, in addition, books for schools and colleges**.¹

In addition to this work of translating and printing the Bible, the Serampore Trio also conducted several schools for boys and girls at Serampore, Calcutta and other outlying stations.

On the whole, the Serampore Trio did not come into any serious conflict with the officials of the Company except on one occasion. In 1808, they published certain tracts called *Addresses to Hindus and Mahomedans*. These were so worded as to offend

¹M. A. Sherring: *The History of Protestant Missions in India*, p. 75.

the religious sentiments of the Indian people and, therefore, the Company prohibited their circulation within its territories. It really wanted to take some more drastic action and directed that their press should be removed to Calcutta so as to bring it under the proper control of the Company's officials. This would have been a great blow to their work; but the Danish Governor intervened and finally, the earlier order was withdrawn and the Trio were directed to "submit works intended for circulation in the Company's territories to the inspection of its officers".¹ This incident made them more careful in their proselytization although it did not affect their educational activities in any way.

As pointed out by Richter in the following extract, the extent and volume of mission work in India was very small even in 1813.

Taken all in all, it was a day of small things. About 1812, there existed mission stations at Serampore (still in the hands of the Danes) whence Calcutta was worked; outstations of the Baptists of Dinajpur, in the indigo district, where Carey had laboured before settling in Serampore; and at Jessore, in the well-watered delta-district of Eastern Bengal. The London Missionary Society was busy in Dutch Chinsura and at Vizagapatam. In Madras and the Tamil country no new work had as yet sprung up alongside that of the veteran fathers of the Danish Mission. In the Kanarese country there was only the solitary station of Bellary, and that had been founded in 1812. In Bombay the first missionaries of a non-English Society, the American Board, had after great anxiety just managed to obtain a foothold. The only seed which appeared to be sprouting hopefully was the work of the Ringeltaube in Southern Travancore.²

Change in the Company's Attitude to Missionary Enterprise: This slow growth of missionary enterprise prior to 1813 was due to several causes, the most important of which was probably the hostile attitude of the East India Company. As shown already in Section 2 *supra*, the attitude of the Com-

¹M.A. Sherring: *op. cit.*, p. 71.

²J.A. Richter: *op. cit.*, p. 49.

pany was generally favourable to missionary enterprise prior to 1765. But a change began to come about as soon as the Company became a political power in India. The acquisition of sovereignty made the Company conscious of the political importance of maintaining strict religious neutrality and this realisation made it abandon all its earlier inclinations towards proselytization and to lose all its former sympathy for missionary enterprise. As the Company's empire began to grow, it became more and more particular to maintain religious neutrality and to sever all connection with missionary enterprise. Incidents like that of the Sepoy Mutiny at Vellore strengthened these ideas and by about 1800, the East India Company became a staunch opponent of all attempts at proselytization and tried to keep the missionaries out of its territories as far as possible. In the same way, the adoption of the Orientalist policy in education between 1781 and 1791 deprived the mission schools of the sympathy and support of the Company which they had enjoyed so far.

The missionaries did not like these changes and began to criticise the new policies and to plead for a return to the old days. As early as in 1793, when the Charter of the Company came up for renewal, Wilberforce moved the following Resolution in the House of Commons:

That it is the peculiar and bounden duty of the British Legislature to promote by all just and prudent means the interest and happiness of the inhabitants of the British Dominions in India; and that for these ends such measures ought to be adopted as may gradually tend to their advancement in useful knowledge and to their religious and moral improvement.¹

But Wilberforce realised that a pious resolution like this had no administrative value; and hence he proposed to insert a clause in the Company's Charter to the effect that

the Court of Directors of the Company shall be empowered and commissioned to nominate and send out from time to time sufficient number of skilled and suitable persons who shall

¹J.A. Richter: *op. cit.*, p. 149.

attain the aforesaid object by serving as schoolmasters, missionaries, or otherwise.¹

The Court of Directors opposed this violently. They had now fully realised the importance of the policy of religious neutrality in consolidating their empire in India and also knew that the missionary with his excessive zeal for conversions invariably got into trouble with the Indian people. Nor were they apparently anxious to undertake the duty of educating the Indian people even apart from giving them religious guidance as desired by Wilberforce. For political and financial reasons, therefore, they urged that "the Hindus had as a good system of faith and of morals as most people and that it would be madness to attempt their conversion or to give them any more learning or any other description of learning than what they already possessed,"² and the proposal of Wilberforce was negatived by Parliament.

This defeat gave a great set-back to missionary enterprise. The Company's position on the missionary issue was now greatly strengthened and it began to put all possible obstacles in the path of the missionaries who worked in its dominions. This active hostility of the Company enraged the missionaries who, in their turn, began to criticise, not only the anti-missionary policy of the Company, but its political and commercial undertakings and even the personal conduct of its officials. The following passage from Richter will give the reader an idea of the nature of such criticism:

Further, the English officials had, almost without exception, abandoned the principles of Christian morality. Even a Governor-General like Warren Hastings and his inconvenient rival, Philip Francis, were not ashamed to live in open adultery. Their sole connection with the Church was that once a year, at Christmas or at Easter, they attended divine service in great state. . . . Over-zealous Orientalists, moreover, sang the praises of the religions of the East, especially of the then newly discovered Indian religions and systems of philosophy, and even if every one did not go so far as to declare them to be better

¹Ibid., p. 150.

²Selections from Educational Records, Vol. I, p. 17.

and truer than Christianity, still the general opinion was that they were quite good enough for the Hindus, and better adapted to their necessities than Western forms of religion. Besides all this the Company took up the narrow-minded point of view that it would have no European within its territories who was not engaged in its service or who did not hold its passport; if any such person were allowed, he would probably enter into business relationships behind its back and thus lessen its gains: or he might talk about its methods of colonial government on his return home, and there were many things which there was every reason to keep concealed from European eyes and ears.¹

The relations between the missionaries and the officials of the Company became, therefore, extremely strained after 1793.

It may be said without fear of exaggeration that, between 1793 and 1813, the Company did not ordinarily issue a permit to any missionary to work within its territories, expelled several missionaries as soon as they became active and tried to convert people, put every obstacle possible in the way of the missionaries, and did not give any assistance even to mission schools. In India, the missionaries were powerless to fight against this policy. They and their friends, therefore, began an intensive agitation in England with the object of persuading Parliament to legislate on the matter and give the necessary freedom and assistance to missionaries. The foremost among those who thus agitated was Charles Grant—the father of modern education in India.

Grant's Observations: The ideas of Charles Grant on the subject of the education of the Indian people were typically missionary and can be best illustrated by quotations from his *Observations on the State of Society among the Asiatic subjects of Great Britain, particularly with respect to morals; and the means of improving it*. The first point in his thesis was to make the English people realise the utterly immoral and wretched condition of Indian Society. He wrote:

In the worst parts of Europe there are no doubt a great number of men who are sincere, upright and conscientious. In

¹J. A. Richter: *op. cit.*, p. 132.

Bengal, a man of real veracity and integrity is a great phenomenon; one conscientious in the whole of his conduct, it is to be feared, is an unknown character. . . . Power entrusted to a native of Hindoostan seldom fails of being exercised tyrannically, or perverted to the purpose of injustice. Official or ministerial employments of all sorts, and in all gradations are generally used as means of peculation. . . . The distribution of justice. . . has commonly become a traffic in venality; the best cause being obliged to pay for success, and the worst having the opportunity of purchasing it. . . . Such is the power of money, that no crime is more frequent, hardly any less thought of, than perjury. . . . The apathy with which a Hindoo views all persons and interests unconnected with himself, is such as excites the indignation of Europeans. . . . Patriotism is absolutely unknown in Hindoostan.¹

Can all this be literally true? Admittedly, the state of affairs was not quite happy in those last decades of the eighteenth century when the whole country was in the grip of the anarchy that followed the decay of the Mughal Empire. "It was a period when life and property were always in danger and when it was risky to confide even in one's dearest friend or relation; when learning was at a discount, appalling ignorance and superstition prevailed in the land, and the people were harassed by thugs, pindarees or mercenaries in alien employment".² Even after making due allowance for this unhappy background, one cannot but feel that Grant is exaggerating the evils. It is the more easy to think so because such keen observers as Elphinstone, Munro and Metcalfe who came in contact with all sections of Indian society have nowhere expressed a wholesale condemnation of the morals of the average Indian. One may, however, pardon Grant's exaggerations because his motives were honourable and his exaggeration of the existing conditions was solely due to his anxiety to awaken an apathetic British public to a realisation of the extreme urgency for organising the education of the Indian people.

After having painted this exaggerated picture of the depraved

¹M.R. Paranjpe : *A Source Book of Modern Indian Education*, pp. viii-ix.

²*Ibid* , p. viii.

condition of the Indian Society, Grant proceeds to analyse its causes and to suggest a remedy. According to Grant, the causes of the miserable condition of the Indian people were two: ignorance and want of a proper religion. He, therefore, felt that the situation could only be improved if Indians were first educated and finally converted to Christianity. He said:

The true cure of darkness is the introduction of light. The Hindoos err, because they are ignorant; and their errors have never fairly been laid before them. The communication of our light and knowledge to them, would prove the best remedy for their disorders; and this remedy is proposed, from a full conviction that if judiciously and patiently applied, it would have great and happy effects upon them, effects honourable and advantageous for us.¹

The question naturally arose: What should be the medium through which this Western light and knowledge should be communicated to the Indian people? Grant suggested that the English language should be adopted as the medium of instruction. He said:

There are two ways of making this communication: the one is, by the medium of the languages of those countries; the other is, by the medium of our own. In general, when foreign teachers have proposed to instruct the inhabitants of any country, they have used the Vernacular tongue of that people, for a natural and necessary reason, that they could not hope to make any other means of communication intelligible to them. This is not our case in respect of our Eastern dependencies. They are our own, we have possessed them long; many Englishmen reside among the Natives, our language is not unknown there, and it is practicable to diffuse it more widely. The choice, therefore, of either mode, lies open to us; and we are at liberty to consider which is entitled to preference. . . .

The acquisition of a foreign language is, to men of cultivated minds, a matter of no great difficulty. English teachers could, therefore, be sooner qualified to offer instruction in the native

¹Syed Mahmood: *History of English Education in India*, p. 11.

language **than the Indians would be prepared to receive it in ours.** This method would hence come into operation more speedily than the other; and it would also be attended with the advantage of a more careful selection of the matter of instruction. But it would be far more confined and less effectual; it may be termed a species of deciphering. The decipherer is required to unfold, in intelligible words, what was before hidden. Upon every new occasion, he has a similar labour to perform, and the information obtained from him is limited to the single communication then made. All other writings, in the same character still remain, to those who are ignorant of it, unknown; but if they are taught the character itself, they can at once read every writing in which it is used. **Thus superior in point of ultimate advantage does the employment of the English language appear; and upon this ground, we give a preference to that mode, proposing here, that the communication of our knowledge shall be made by the medium of our own language. . . .**

We proceed, then, to observe, that it is perfectly in the power of this country, by degrees, to impart to the Hindoos our language; afterwards, through that medium, to make them acquainted with our easy literary compositions, upon a variety of subjects; and, let not the idea hastily excite derision, progressively with the simple elements of our arts, our philosophy, and religion. These acquisitions would silently undermine, and at length subvert, the fabric of error; and all the objections that may be apprehended against such a change, are, it is confidently believed, capable of a solid answer. . . .

It would be extremely easy for Government to establish, at a moderate expense, in various parts of the provinces, places of gratuitous instruction in reading and writing English; multitudes, especially of the young, would flock to them and the easy books used in teaching, might at the same time convey obvious truths on different subjects. The teachers should be persons of knowledge, morals, and discretion; and men of this character could impart to their pupils much useful information in discourse: **and to facilitate the attainment of that object, they might, at first make some use of the Bengalese tongue.** The Hindoos **would, in time, become teachers of English themselves; and the employment of our language in public business, for which every**

political reason remains in full force, would, in the course of another generation, make it very general throughout the country. There is nothing wanting to the success of this plan, but the hearty patronage of Government. If they wish it to succeed, it can and must succeed. The introduction of English in the Administration of the Revenue, in Judicial proceedings, and in other business of Government, wherein Persian is now used; and the establishment of free schools, for instruction in this language, would insure its diffusion over the country, for the reason already suggested that the interest of the Natives would induce them to acquire it. Neither would much confusion arise, even at first, upon such a change; for there are now a great number of Portuguese and Bengalese clerks in the provinces, who understand both the Hindoostanny and English languages. To employ them in drawing up petitions to Government, or its officers, would be no additional hardship upon the poorer people, who are now assisted in that way by Persian clerks; and the opportunity afforded to others who have sufficient leisure, of learning the language of the Government gratuitously, would be an advantage never enjoyed under Mahomedan Rulers.

With our language, much of our useful literature might, and would, in time, be communicated. The art of printing would enable us to disseminate our writings in a way the Persians never could have done, though their compositions had been as numerous as ours. Hence the Hindoos would see the great use we make of reason on all subjects, and in all affairs; they also would learn to reason, they would become acquainted with the history of their own species, the past and present state of the world; their affections would gradually become interested by various engaging works, composed to recommend virtue, and to deter from vice; the general mass of their opinions would be rectified; and above all, they would see a better system of principles and morals. New views of duty, as rational creatures, would open upon them; and that mental bondage in which they have long been holden would gradually dissolve.¹

Regarding the subjects of instruction, some suggestions of

¹Syed Mahmood : *op. cit.*, pp. 11-13,

Grant can be noted in the passage, quoted above. In addition to these, Grant suggested that special emphasis should be laid on the teaching of natural sciences in order to break down the superstitious beliefs prevalent among the people and on the teaching of the use of mechanical inventions in order to bring about agricultural and industrial development of the country. However, the most precious subject of instruction, according to Grant, was the Christian religion.

After putting forward this scheme for the education of the Indian people, Grant proceeded to answer some of the probable objections that would be raised against it. The first and the foremost objection was that English education was politically dangerous and that if the Indian people were taught the English language and ideas, they would rise up in a revolt, cast off their subjection and assert their independence. Grant was not frightened of such a contingency and would not agree to keep the Indian people in ignorance with a view merely to perpetuating their slavery. He felt that it was the duty of England to educate Indians. He also held that it was really in the best interests of England herself to educate the Hindus and Muslims. Such education would bring about better understanding between the rulers and the ruled, would secure the gratitude of the Indian people, and would ultimately lead to greater extension of British commerce in India. He was, therefore, of the opinion that no misgivings should be allowed to come in the way and that, on grounds of duty as well as of self-interest, the English people should organise the education of the Indians on as large a scale as possible.

Criticism of Grant's Proposals: On the whole, Grant's book is not pleasant to read. A large part of it is taken up by the delineation of the Indian Society of the period and the exaggerations and the one-sided approach of this description rob it alike of historical and educational value. In the same way, no Indian would agree to Grant's view that mass conversions to Christianity alone could regenerate Indian Society. Similarly, Grant's view that the spread of English education would slowly but necessarily make the Indian people accept Christianity has also been disapproved by the history of the last one hundred and fifty years.

Finally, no importance can now be attached to the long and elaborate discussions where Grant advances ridiculous arguments to show that no political dangers can follow from English education or proselytization. Some of these arguments, for instance, are: "Christian teaching favours submission and good order among the people"; "Christianity cannot overcome the debilitating effects of an Eastern climate"; "Vegetable diet and absence of maritime taste among the Hindus will check ardent designs of independence"; "Political liberty cannot flourish among the timid submissive people of India", etc.¹

But the suggestions of Grant regarding the organisation of the education of the Indian people are of great historical interest. It is very significant that, even as early as in 1792, Grant foresaw the future developments in Indian education so clearly. He suggested the adoption of English as the language of Government—a decision which was ultimately taken by Bentinck about forty years later. He also suggested the adoption of English as a medium of instruction—an educationally unsound but curiously prophetic proposal that was accepted later on through the able advocacy of Macaulay. He correctly diagnosed the eagerness of the Indian people to learn the English language and rightly foretold that multitudes of the young would flock to the English schools and that Indians themselves would, in course of time, be teachers of English. It is because of these practical and prophetic suggestions that Grant's book still retains its interest and it is because of them that Grant is sometimes described as the father of modern education in India.

In educating contemporary English opinion on the subject and in making Parliament realise the urgent necessity of organising the education of the Indian people, the *Observations* played a very important role. The book was published in 1797 and its copies were broadcast. Friends of the missionaries made it the basis of their agitation and argued that the Company was following a wrong and an un-Christian policy in refusing to allow missionaries to work in its territories. The prestige of Grant as one who had known India at first hand, as an influential Director of the Company, and a Member of Parliament lent weight to the book and ultimately paved the way for the educational clauses

¹Syed Mahmood: *op. cit.*, pp. 216-18.

of the Charter Act of 1813.

Agitation by Company's Officials: *Minto's Minute:* While the missionaries were thus agitating in England for a change in the Company's educational policy, the officials of the Company in India were also agitating for a bolder move in expanding Oriental education. They felt that the maintenance of the Calcutta Madrasah and the Banaras Sanskrit College was like a drop in the ocean; they grieved at the decay into which Hindu and Muslim learning had fallen and asked for larger funds and a more vigorous drive to revive and improve the classical learning of this ancient country. As a typical statement on the subject, a reference may be made to the **Minute of Lord Minto who was the Governor-General of India from 1806 to 1813**. Minto was personally an admirer of Oriental Literature and felt that its study would be useful to the Western nations themselves. He was, therefore, very anxious that Englishmen should give all possible encouragement to the study and preservation of Indian Culture. In a Minute, dated 6th March 1811, he wrote:

It is a common remark that science and literature are in a progressive state of decay among the natives of India. From every inquiry which I have been enabled to make on this interesting subject, that remark appears to me but too well founded. The number of the learned is not only diminished, but the circle of learning, even among those who still devote themselves to it, appears to be considerably contracted. The abstract sciences are abandoned, polite literature neglected, and no branch of learning cultivated but what is connected with the peculiar religious doctrines of the people. The immediate consequence of this state of things is the disuse, and even actual loss, of many valuable books; and it is to be apprehended that, unless Government interfere with a fostering hand, the revival of letters may shortly become hopeless from a want of books, or of persons capable of explaining them.

The principal cause of the present neglected state of literature in India is to be traced to the want of that encouragement which was formerly afforded to it by princes, chieftains, and opulent individuals under the native governments. Such

encouragement must always operate as a strong incentive to study and literary exertions, but especially in India, where the learned professions have little, if any other, support. . . .

It is seriously to be lamented that a nation particularly distinguished for its love and successful cultivation of letters in other parts of the empire should have failed to extend its fostering care to the literature of the Hindoos, and to aid in opening to the learned in Europe the repositories of that literature.¹

The officials of the Company, therefore, tried to pull exactly in the opposite direction and a violent controversy ensued between the friends and supporters of the Missions on the one hand and the Orientalists or Company's officials on the other.

The Charter Act of 1813: It was against such a background that the Charter of the Company came up for renewal in 1813. Among others, the most important educational issues discussed on this occasion were the following:

- (a) Should missionaries be allowed to go to India and work in the territories of the Company for the education and proselytization of the Indian people?
- (b) Should the Company accept responsibility for the education of the Indian people? If it should, what should be the nature and scope of its educational activities?

On the first of these issues, the missionaries and their friends scored a clean victory. As Richter observes:

The 13th Resolution, the one in which the whole missionary question was really involved, ran as follows: 'Resolved, that it is the opinion of this Committee that it is the duty of this country to promote the interests and happiness of the native inhabitants of the British dominions in India, and that measures ought to be adopted as may tend to the introduction among them of useful knowledge and moral improvement. That

¹ *Report of the Select Committee of the House of Commons on the Affairs of the East India Company (1832), Appendix I, pp. 325-27.*

in furtherance of the above objects sufficient facilities shall be afforded by law to persons desirous of going to, or remaining in, India for the purpose of accomplishing those benevolent designs'. That meant that the missionaries were to be allowed to enter India and to reside there; they might preach, found churches, and discharge all spiritual duties; in a word, they might fulfil their missionary calling in its completest and widest sense. . . .¹

On the second issue, the principal opposition to acceptance of responsibility came from the Directors. In those days, education was not regarded as a responsibility of the State even in England; and very naturally, the East India Company was not prepared to accept it in India. Secondly, the Company was influenced more by financial than by philanthropic motives and resisted all attempts to increase obligations having a tendency to cut down the dividends. Thirdly, the people of India themselves were most apathetic in the matter. Oppressed by the anarchy that followed the decay of the Moghal Empire, their one great need was the establishment of law and order and they hardly had the time or energy to ask for anything else from their rulers. The task of making the Company accept responsibility for the education of the Indian people was, therefore, far from easy. But the opponents of the *mission clauses* felt an urgent need of creating a powerful and rival agency in Indian education to counteract the results of missionary enterprise. They, therefore, moved and successfully carried through a resolution which subsequently became the 43rd Section in the Charter. It is quoted below:

It shall be lawful for the Governor-General in Council to direct that out of any surplus which may remain of the rents, revenues, and profits arising from the said territorial acquisitions, after defraying the expenses of the military, civil and commercial establishments and paying the interest of the debt, in manner hereinafter provided, a sum of not less than one lac of rupees in each year shall be set apart and applied to the revival and improvement of literature and the encouragement of the learned natives of India and for the introduction and promotion of a

¹ J. A. Richter: *op. cit.*, pp. 150-51.

knowledge of the science among the inhabitants of the British territories in India.¹

The sponsors of this Section were obviously influenced by the Oriental School of thought because they spoke of the *revival and improvement of literature* (which referred to the Classical literatures in Sanskrit or Arabic) and of *encouragement of the learned natives of India*. But they were also anxious to teach western science because the Indian people of this period were most ignorant in them and desired that attempts should be made to promote *a knowledge of the sciences among the inhabitants of the British territories in India*. The principal implication of this clause was that the Company would create its own agency to spend this amount of a lakh of rupees and try to educate the people of India in a *secular and conservative* fashion as opposed to the proselytizing and revolutionary proposals of the missionaries. The supporters of this resolution believed that "by fostering both Oriental and Occidental science. . . a reliable counterpoise, a protecting breakwater against the threatened deluge of missionary enterprise"² would be created. They little dreamed that this Section of the Act was laying the foundation of a state educational system in India which would fuse both the Government and missionary schools into a common structure in due course.

The Charter Act of 1813, therefore, forms a turning point in the history of Indian education. With it, the agitation which Grant and Wilberforce carried on for nearly twenty years came to a successful conclusion; the education of the Indian people was definitely included within the duties of the Company; a comparatively large amount was annually secured for educational activities; and missionaries began to land in India in large numbers and establish English schools, thereby laying the foundation of the modern educational system.

¹ W. H. Sharp: *op. cit.*, p. 22.

² J. A. Richter: *op. cit.* p. 152.